NCFE Level 2 Functional Skills Qualification in English (603/5054/4): Writing

Paper number: Sample Assessment Materials

Mark Scheme v1.0

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Markers' briefing note

Marks in the English Writing component are awarded for 'independent understanding of written language in specific contexts'. Whilst the learner may use the content of the scenarios to inform their writing, the writing activities do not assess reading skills or interpretation of any stimuli.

Learners are expected to produce an open response. Depending on the context of the activity, a learner may support either side of an argument, or adopt any well-reasoned stance, using the scenarios and / or their own ideas and experiences. What should be assessed is their ability to do this whilst meeting all the subject content statements.

Subject content statements (SCS)

L2.3.20 Punctuate correctly, using a wide range of punctuation markers (for example, colons, commas, inverted commas, apostrophes, and quotation marks)
L2.3.21 Use correct grammar (for example, subject-verb agreement, consistent use of a range of tenses, definite and indefinite articles) and modality devices (for example, to express probability or desirability)
L2.3.22 Spell words used in work, study and daily life, including a range of specialist words
L2.3.23 Communicate information, ideas and opinions clearly, coherently and effectively
L2.3.24 Write text of an appropriate level of detail and of appropriate length (including where this is specified) to meet the needs of purpose and audience
L2.3.25 Organise writing for different purposes using the appropriate format and structure (for example, standard templates, paragraphs, bullet points, tables)
L2.3.26 Convey clear meaning and establish cohesion using organisational markers effectively
L2.3.27 Use different language and register (for example, persuasive techniques, supporting evidence, specialist words) suited to the audience and purpose
L2.3.28 Construct complex sentences consistently and accurately, using paragraphs where appropriate

The following relates to both activities unless otherwise indicated.

<table>
<tr><td colspan="3">Marking guidance

Notes

• Judgements should be made for quality of responses expected at level 2.
• A response does not have to be error-free to be awarded full marks.
• A response does not have to demonstrate all bullets in the mark band to be awarded the mark. A ‘best-fit’ approach should be taken to the awarding of the Spelling, Punctuation and Grammar (SPaG) marks.</td><td>Marks</td><td>Subject content ref.</td></tr>
<tr><td colspan="5">Spelling, Punctuation and Grammar (SPaG)</td></tr>
<tr><td colspan="5">• For responses under 100 words, examiners should apply professional judgement when awarding SPaG marks. Typically, shorter responses will not contain sufficient evidence to access the full nine marks for SPaG. However, where a shorter response demonstrates clear accuracy, control, and range in language use, it may still achieve full marks for SPaG.</td></tr>
<tr><td colspan="5">Punctuation: zero marks should be given for no awardable content</td></tr>
<tr><td colspan="5">One of the following:</td></tr>
<tr><td>[1 mark]
A limited range of punctuation has been used, but not always correctly. Errors may affect meaning and / or readability.

• Some punctuation has been used, but not always correctly. Errors may affect meaning and / or readability.
• Beginning and end of sentence punctuation is correct (including question marks and exclamation marks).
• Other punctuation marks may be used inconsistently or incorrectly.</td><td>[2 marks]
A range of punctuation has been used, mostly correctly. Errors do not affect meaning, although reading may be more difficult.

• Generally correct punctuation, including the punctuation of sentences and use of commas, where appropriate.
• Generally correct use of apostrophes where used.</td><td>[3 marks]
A range of punctuation has been used correctly. Minor errors do not affect meaning or readability.

• Consistently correct punctuation.
• Where used, colons, commas, inverted commas, apostrophes and quotation marks are consistently accurate.

Note: full marks should be given for responses demonstrating control and consistently correct punctuation, including responses that do not include a range of punctuation.</td><td>3</td><td>SCS 20</td></tr>
</table>

Grammar: zero marks should be given for no awardable content				
One of the following:				
[1 mark] Grammatical errors make reading difficult. • **Some** correct grammatical constructions. For example, variation in verb forms and tense choices. • Errors may affect meaning. **Note**: award mark if **one** grammatically correct sentence has been written.	**[2 marks]** Basic grammar is correct. Where more complex grammar is attempted, errors do **not** affect meaning, although reading may be more difficult. • **Generally** correct grammatical constructions. • **Generally** appropriate use of tense and definite / indefinite articles.	**[3 marks]** Grammatical errors are minor and have little impact on meaning and readability. • Grammar is **consistently** correct at level 2 • A wide range of sentence types are constructed consistently correctly.	3	SCS 21
Spelling: zero marks should be given for no awardable content				
One of the following:				
[1 mark] Incorrect spelling affects meaning and / or readability in places. • **Some** correct spelling. For example, simple everyday words, including some plurals will be correct but there may be frequent errors in more complex words. • Errors may affect meaning.	**[2 marks]** Correct spelling of straightforward words. Errors in some ambitious words are minor and do **not** affect meaning. • **Generally** correct spelling including specialist words and complex words (including ambitious words). • Errors do **not** affect meaning.	**[3 marks]** Correct spelling of straightforward words, and **some** ambitious and / or specialist words. • **Consistently** correct spelling (including specialist words and ambitious words, words with complex sound / symbol relationships and words with unstressed syllables).	3	SCS 22
		Marks available	**9**	

<table>
<tr><th colspan="5">Writing composition</th></tr>
<tr><th colspan="5">Content: zero marks should be given for no awardable content</th></tr>
<tr><td colspan="3">One of the following:</td><td></td><td></td></tr>
<tr><td>[1 mark]
The response:

• has some clarity and coherence
• is sometimes effective in communicating information, ideas and opinions.</td><td>[2 marks]
The response:

• is generally clear and coherent
• is generally effective in communicating information, ideas and opinions.

Note: coverage of topic may be list like, scant or tangential.</td><td>[3 marks]
The response:

• is consistently clear with minor lapses of coherence
• is consistently effective in communicating information, ideas and opinions.

Note: occasional lapses do not impact coherence overall.</td><td>3</td><td>SCS 23</td></tr>
<tr><th colspan="5">Detail: zero marks should be given for no awardable content</th></tr>
<tr><td colspan="3">• The response is appropriately detailed to meet the needs of the audience and purpose. [1 mark]</td><td>1</td><td>SCS 24</td></tr>
<tr><td colspan="3">• The response is of an appropriate length for the purpose and audience, including where not specified. [1 mark]</td><td>1</td><td>SCS 24</td></tr>
<tr><td colspan="5">Note for SCS 24:

A response must meet the requirements of the word count (where given) to be awarded this mark. If no word count is stated then responses should be over 100 words to be awarded this mark. However, the length mark should be awarded to responses that demonstrate concision, even if they are shorter than 100 words.

Notes for SCS 23 and 24:

Activity 1 / 2
• Prompts do not need to be strictly adhered to in order to access all available marks. Full marks are awardable so long as the response is relevant to the question, clear, and otherwise successfully meets criteria for SCS 23 and 24.</td></tr>
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<tr><td colspan="2">Format and structure: zero marks should be given for no awardable content</td><td></td><td></td></tr>
<tr><td colspan="2">Formatting

Award one mark for the main formatting feature, up to a maximum of two marks where an additional feature is also used.

• Main formatting feature is used (see appendix). [1 mark]
• There is one additional relevant formatting feature (see appendix). [1 mark]

Notes

• The main formatting feature must be attempted to award a mark for an additional feature.
• Email tasks must have correct email address and an appropriate subject line to achieve main formatting feature mark (see appendix).</td><td>2</td><td>SCS 25</td></tr>
<tr><td colspan="2">Structure
• There is a recognisable structure (beginning, middle and end). [1 mark]</td><td>1</td><td>SCS 25</td></tr>
<tr><td colspan="2">Organisational markers (linking words): zero marks should be given for no awardable content</td><td></td><td></td></tr>
<tr><td colspan="2">• Uses organisational markers to create cohesion. [1 mark]

Notes
Organisational markers:

• can begin a new sentence / paragraph
• can link ideas using words and phrases (for example, first, in contrast, however)
• are words and phrases to refer backwards, look forward, and connect ideas across paragraphs (for example, pronouns, synonyms, repetition, demonstratives, cause and effect patterns)
• can be used throughout the response.</td><td>1</td><td>SCS 26</td></tr>
<tr><td colspan="2">Language and register: zero marks should be given for no awardable content</td><td></td><td></td></tr>
<tr><td colspan="4">One of the following:</td></tr>
<tr><td>[1 mark]
• Language and register (formality) are generally suited to audience and purpose.</td><td>[2 marks]
• Language and register (formality) are consistently suited to audience and purpose.</td><td>2</td><td>SCS 27</td></tr>
</table>

Note: if the response is below **75** words, it has not **consistently** demonstrated language and register suited to audience and purpose, and only **one** language and register mark can be awarded.		
Paragraphs and complex sentences: zero marks should be given for no awardable content		
Award **one** mark for any of the following, up to a maximum of two marks. • At least **two** paragraphs used appropriately. **[1 mark]** • At least **two** accurately demarcated complex sentences. **[1 mark]** **Note**: grammar is assessed separately. Do **not** penalise minor lapses in grammar (for example, subject-verb agreement).	2	SCS 28
Marks available	13	
Total marks available per activity	22	
Overall total (Activity 1 and Activity 2) marks available	44	

Appendix: level 2 SCS 25 format indicative content

- Essential formatting features are emboldened below.
- Other appropriate formatting features should be rewarded.
- Any additional formatting feature should only be awarded if the mark for essential formatting feature has been attempted.

Formal letter	**Sender's postal address** • Recipient's address • Date • Salutation and matching close **Notes**: • **Only** accept the salutation 'Dear [name]' with the matching close 'Yours sincerely' **or** the salutation 'Dear Sir / Madam' with the matching close 'Yours faithfully' • mark to be awarded if name of sender is included above sender's address.	**Email**	**Recipient's email address correctly spelt and appropriate subject line** • Suitable salutation and matching close **Note**: do **not** accept Hi / To whom it may concern.
Article	**Heading** • Subheadings • Bullet points • Author's name	**Leaflet**	**Heading** • Subheadings • Bullet points • Numbering
Review	**Heading** • Subheadings • Bullet points • Author's name	**Formal report**	**Heading** • Subheadings • Bullet points • Numbering • Author's name